

If vs When

CEFR B1

Lesson Pack · summary, worksheet & answer key

Quick answer

Both link a future condition to a result, but they differ in certainty:

- 1 if — a possibility that may not happen (If I have time, I'll help).
- 2 when — a certainty; only the time is open (When I finish, I'll rest).

After if and when, use the present simple for the future — never 'will': When it starts, not 'when it will start'.

At a glance

Word	Certainty	Example
if	it may or may not happen	If it rains, we'll stay in.
when	it will definitely happen (timing unknown)	When I get home, I'll call you.

Learning objectives

- Can choose 'if' (possible) or 'when' (certain) for future events (CEFR B1).
- Can use the present simple after if/when for the future.
- Can recognise 'when' meaning 'whenever' for repeated situations.

Practice worksheet

Circle the correct option. If vs When · CEFR B1

Name: _____

Date: _____

1. ____ the sun goes down, it gets cold here. (certain)

- | | |
|-----------|------------|
| A. When | B. If |
| C. Unless | D. Whether |

2. ____ it rains tomorrow, we'll cancel the picnic. (uncertain)

- | | |
|-------|---------|
| A. If | B. When |
| C. As | D. Once |

3. I'll call you ____ I get to the airport. (certain arrival)

- | | |
|-----------|------------|
| A. when | B. if |
| C. unless | D. whether |

4. ____ you need anything, just let me know. (possible)

- | | |
|---------------|---------|
| A. If | B. When |
| C. As soon as | D. Once |

5. Choose the present simple: 'When it ____ , I'll open the window.'

- | | |
|-------------------|-----------------|
| A. gets hot | B. will get hot |
| C. is getting hot | D. got hot |

6. We'll move to a bigger house ____ the baby is born. (certain)

- | | |
|-----------|------------|
| A. when | B. if |
| C. unless | D. in case |

7. ____ I win the competition, I'll be amazed. (unlikely)

- | | |
|---------------|---------|
| A. If | B. When |
| C. As soon as | D. Once |

8. ____ I drink coffee late, I can't sleep. (a general pattern)

- | | |
|-----------|------------|
| A. When | B. If only |
| C. Unless | D. In case |

9. Correct this: 'When I will finish work, I'll come over.'

- | | |
|---|---|
| A. When I finish work, I'll come over. | B. When I will finish work, I'll come over. |
| C. If I will finish work, I'll come over. | D. When I finishing work, I'll come over. |

10. Which word shows the event is CERTAIN, only the time is unknown?

- | | |
|-----------|------------|
| A. when | B. if |
| C. unless | D. whether |

Answer key

Correct answers with explanations · for the teacher

1. **A. When** — The sun definitely goes down, so 'when'.
2. **A. If** — Rain is uncertain, so 'if'.
3. **A. when** — You will arrive, so 'when I get to the airport'.
4. **A. If** — Needing something is a possibility, so 'if'.
5. **A. gets hot** — Use the present simple after 'when': 'when it gets hot'.
6. **A. when** — The baby will be born, so 'when'.
7. **A. If** — Winning is unlikely/uncertain, so 'if'.
8. **A. When** — 'When' = 'whenever' for a repeated pattern.
9. **A. When I finish work, I'll come over.** — Use the present simple after 'when': 'When I finish work'.
10. **A. when** — 'When' = it will happen; only the timing is open.